

LESSON 2 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Perspective & Volume

How to draw objects that feel three-dimensional and exist convincingly in space.

Overview

Perspective is the grammar of 3D drawing. Without it, objects look flat, spaces feel unconvincing, and forms collapse. With it, even simple line drawings communicate depth, scale, and solidity. The goal of this lesson is to internalize perspective well enough that you stop consciously applying rules and start feeling spatial relationships intuitively.

That intuition takes time. In the short term, you'll need to draw deliberately — placing horizon lines, finding vanishing points, checking edge convergence. Over weeks and months, these checks become instinctive. Draw boxes every day. Hundreds of them. It is the single highest-return exercise in drawing.

CORE CONCEPTS

The Horizon Line & Eye Level

The horizon line in a drawing represents the viewer's eye level. Objects above the horizon are seen from below; objects below are seen from above. This single line governs every perspective relationship in your picture. When an object looks "wrong," the first thing to check is whether its edges converge to a point on the horizon.

One-Point Perspective

When you look straight down a hallway, road, or railroad track, edges that run away from you all converge to a single **vanishing point** (VP) on the horizon. This is one-point perspective. It creates a strong sense of depth but looks mechanical if overused. Best for interior scenes and objects facing directly toward the viewer.

Two-Point Perspective

When you look at the corner of a building, edges run away in two different directions toward two separate vanishing points. This is the most useful perspective mode — it handles most architectural and object-based drawing scenarios. Vertical edges remain perfectly vertical; only the horizontal edges converge.

Three-Point Perspective

Add a third vanishing point above or below the horizon for dramatic foreshortening — looking up at a skyscraper, or down from a rooftop. Vertical edges now converge too, creating the illusion of massive scale. Use sparingly; it reads as extreme unless that's the intent.

Foreshortening

When a form points directly toward the viewer, it appears compressed — its length appears shorter than its width. A foreshortened arm pointing at you looks almost as wide as it is long. The key to drawing foreshortened forms convincingly is to trust what you see, not what you know the object's true length to be.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Box-a-Day Challenge

- Draw 20–30 boxes per session in 2-point perspective from imagination.
- Vary size, orientation, and eye level. Some boxes above the horizon, some below.
- Check every edge: do the top edges converge to VP1 and VP2? Do verticals stay vertical?
- This exercise is foundational. Commit to it daily for the entire lesson.

EXERCISE 2

Room Interior in 1-Point Perspective

- Draw a simple room interior from memory: floor, ceiling, back wall, left wall, right wall.
- Add a window, a door, and one piece of furniture. All edges converge to one VP.
- Focus on consistent eye level — don't let the VP drift.
- Try once from below eye level (looking up at the ceiling) and once from above (bird's eye).

EXERCISE 3

Object Deconstruction

- Choose a moderately complex object: camera, sneaker, chair, backpack.
- Break it into 5–8 overlapping box-like forms. Draw those boxes in perspective first.
- Only after the box structure is correct, refine edges to match the real object's curves and details.
- This workflow — structure before surface — is used by professional concept artists.

CURATED FREE RESOURCES

Draw a Box — Lesson 1 (Boxes) + Lesson 6 (Applying Perspective)drawabox.com · Free Course

The gold standard free program for learning perspective through structured box-drawing. Non-negotiable.

Peter Han — Dynamic Sketching (YouTube)youtube.com · Video

Industrial designer and teacher with exceptional perspective instruction for product and concept sketching.

How to Draw — Scott Robertson (Book Supplement)youtube.com · Video

Scott Robertson's supplemental YouTube content accompanies his definitive book on perspective drawing.

Ctrl+Paint — Perspective & Space Libraryctrlpaint.com/topics/perspective · Course

Free library section covering perspective types, vanishing points, and spatial depth in painting.

Marc Brunet — Perspective Made Simpleyoutube.com · Video

Practical, sketchbook-oriented perspective instruction. Great for artists who find textbook approaches confusing.

Proko — Drawing in Perspectiveyoutube.com/@Proko · Video

Proko's perspective-focused content covering foreshortening and drawing figures in perspective.

Line of Action — Daily Perspective Practiceline-of-action.com · Tool

Use the environment/interior mode for timed reference studies of real spaces.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: 20–30 boxes before anything else. This is non-negotiable for this lesson. No shortcuts.

Weekly: Draw one scene from life — a corner of a room, a street view, a desktop setup — using proper 1 or 2-point perspective to structure it first.